

Skills Summary

Taking Away Objects and Writing Subtraction Equations

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — Take Away Objects and Count What Is Left

The model: start with a group, cross out the ones taken away, count what has *no* X.

The words match the equation:

- how many you **start** with → the first number
- how many are **taken away** → the number after the minus sign
- how many are **left** → the number after the equals sign

Example: There are 8 counters. Cross out 3 of them.

Step 1. Taking away means some counters leave the group, so this is a subtraction picture, not an adding one.

Step 2. Cross out 3 counters, then touch and count only the ones with no X: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5. So $8 - 3 = 5$.

Try it: There are 6 counters. Cross out 4. How many are left?

check: 2

Skill 2 — Write the Subtraction Equation for a Story

Rule: start – taken away = left.

Words that mean **take away**: fly away, eat, give away, pop, leave, lose, break. Write the number you *started* with first — it is always the biggest number in a take-away story.

Example: 7 fish are in a tank. 4 fish are moved to another tank.

Step 1. “Moved away” takes fish out of the tank, so the 7 is the whole group and the 4 is the part that leaves.

Step 2. Write the whole first, then the part taken: $7 - 4$. Counting the fish left gives $7 - 4 = 3$.

Try it: 9 balloons. 6 balloons pop. Write the equation and the answer.

check: 3

Skill 3 — Find the Missing Part

When the middle number is missing: $\text{start} - \underline{\quad} = \text{left}$.

Count **up** from the number left to the number you started with. Every count you say is one object that was taken away. Then check by taking that many away.

Example: 8 stickers. Some are used. 5 stickers are left. How many were used?

Step 1. The whole (8) and the leftover part (5) are known, so the missing number is the part that was taken away.

Step 2. Count up from 5 to 8: “6, 7, 8” is 3 counts. Check: $8 - 3 = 5$ ✓, so the missing part is 3.

Try it: 10 crackers. Some are eaten. 2 are left. How many were eaten?

8 :pæp

(!) Watch out: After you cross out, count the objects with *no* X. Counting the crossed-out ones answers a different question. Also keep the bigger number first: a take-away story is never written $2 - 5$.